arrested Sasikumaran on 14 November. The police had found in Mariam's diary the telephone numbers of Sasikumaran's residence and office.

It later turned out that Sasikumaran did know Mariam through a common friend called Chandrasekhar, with whom ISRO had a business in connection with the cryogenic project. Chandrasekhar, who met Mariam at the Trivandrum airport, had put her on to Sasikumaran for a consultation with his wife who was a doctor. Some admissible evidence of their meeting with Mariam was to become clear to me only much later.

A fortnight after Sasikumaran's arrest, on 30 November morning, Gopi, Mohana Prasad and Isaac Mathew, an industrialist friend close to my family, came to my place. It was unusual for the trio to be there without notice. They looked glum. Having seated them in the drawing room, I asked what was wrong. They looked at each other.

'Is someone unwell?' I prodded. After a minute of silence, Isaac spoke.

'Nambi, you will be arrested today.'

I said he must be joking. He explained that he had come to know the previous night from an IB officer called Mathew John that I would be arrested. The three friends discussed the matter and debated whether to tell me the previous night, but decided to come personally this morning to break the news.

Now that the possibility had sunk in, I called my son Sankara Kumar. 'See, I don't know if it is true, but I may be arrested,' I told him. As we were talking my wife Meena passed by and we fell silent. We did not want her to know anything now. I told my son that my bank balance was poor, maybe a few thousands of rupees there, but don't worry about money since he can ask Isaac or Mohana Prasad. Sankar went out to find out if the news was authentic. He got back early afternoon. One look at his face and I knew it. He started crying.

'They're coming for you, Appa,' he sobbed.

At the Vanchiyoor Police Station I was asked to sit on a bench. Policemen kept passing by, some throwing nasty glances at me, some others just curious. A constable stared at me with an expression that reflected utter contempt. I couldn't stand it and shouted, 'Why are you staring at me?'